

have realised this, and throughout this test you'll see devices specifically designed for a particular use and performing other tasks as well—sort of like a jack of all trades and master of one.

FLASH-BASED PMPS
BELOW RS 5,000

Sure, PMPs scale with price, and you get exactly what you pay for, but not everybody wants a high-end PMP with excellent performance and features to boot. That doesn't mean that a value-based player has to be a compromise. *Au contraire*, sub-Rs 5,000 players have a host of features that were previously available only on much costlier models. Part of the diminishing cost is due to the sharply declining prices of flash memory—prices have dropped to quarter of their values a year ago. Equally to blame is the increasing popularity of PMPs—nothing mysterious, just the simple laws of economics at work. So, you can get a very good sounding PMP, with features like FM radio, text document support, and basic add-on features like an alarm, stopwatch, and even PIM features like contact management.

Features

Of all the players we received, the concept of a watch that's an MP3 player as well was somewhat exciting. The Aigo U Watch MP3

is a nice little item—cool and funky-looking with all the settings of a good MP3 player, including an equaliser. It loses out on FM support, and of course, video playback isn't possible. It's also let down by an un-intuitive and painful menu system, and the fact that you'll have a cord dangling from your wrist doesn't help any. Transcend's T.Sonic 840 comes in a piano white facia with a solid steel back that is (thankfully) not chrome plated, but matte—no smudges! It's a full-fledged multimedia player with music, photo and video capabilities, and has a pretty good screen to boot. The buttons seem a little tacky, but not as bad as some of the other players. iRiver's S7 is another cool looking player—its front surface looks like a magic cube with indented intersecting grooves built into it. The S7 is meant to be worn around your neck—and it's certainly attractive enough. YES had four players in this comparison—and all their players in this category have been in our labs last year. Creative's Zen Stone and Zen Stone Plus are very compact looking players shaped like pebbles—the difference being the screen on the Plus.

The Sansa Shaker was another novelty—it looks like a salt cellar (hence the name), and

although it isn't feature rich, it's good for kids, owing to its tough body. Apacer's Steno AU581 sports a grey metallic finish that is dominated by a crisp blue OLED screen. Zebronic's had the smallest players in test—both the Beta and the Gamma are compact and solidly built, and sport OLED screens. Zebronic's Gamma has a very nice feature where music fades in if the player is paused and then un-paused, so your ears don't get blasted. Sony's Duo—the NWD-B103F and NWD-B105F—are designed to look like large flash drives, and there's no hassle of a USB cable—you can just plug the player into a USB port. Needless to say, both are built really well despite their plastic bodies. The pearl-white finish is bright, without being overly flashy. Another pen-drive-like player, the SanDisk Sansa Express attracted and held our attention. It's built like a little brick, and sports an aesthetic pearl grey finish. The front is dominated by a legible OLED screen. Both the SanDisk Sansa Express and the Transcend T.Sonic 840 have very well laid-out menus—the former is very simple and uncomplicated—a boon when dealing with a small screen—while the T.Sonic 840 scores on usability due to its much larger screen and intu-

itive interface. The Aigo MP-F585 is a well-built and compact player with a smudge-attracting chrome finished rear. The only irritation here are the small and tacky buttons.

Performance

Sony's duo offered good performance—while the overall bass seemed a little muddy on the Bose earplugs, things sounded just right with the Audio Technica circum-aural cans. One complaint was the volume levels on both these players—not as high as we'd like—far from ringing, our ears barely even got warmed up...

The Transcend T.Sonic 840 suffers from sluggish performance. Navigating menus will cause music to skip—not a good thing at all; keep your hands off it while tuning in to your favourite tunes. Both the T.Sonic 840 and the T.Sonic 610 offer good music quality, but the former is a better player as far as vocals go—a strong mid-range is never bad. The T.Sonic 840 is a decent video player mainly due to its clear screen, but with the issue of processing juice rearing its ugly head again, movies weren't the experience we hoped they'd be. With its lighter interface and the OLED screen, the cheaper T.Sonic 610 doesn't have the issues that plague its pricier sibling.

The cute Aigo U Watch MP3 may be fun as a wristwatch, but it wasn't as much fun to listen to. With boomy bass and a very restricted top end, we were disappointed—novelty is no substitute for performance. Its costlier sibling has overly bright female vocals, with a little extra colouring in the top end of the vocal spectrum. Male voices sound spot on and the mids are strong, even over-emphasised. Both the Sony players impressed us with their sound quality, good highs, and nice instrument detail—unfortunately, they don't go up to even normal listening volumes, let alone loud volumes. SanDisk's Sansa Express is an impressive music offering.

The YES YMP 30 is the best music player from amongst the YES players—the YMP 18 has some issues with female vocals—they sound harsh and the volume needs to be turned down to prevent an earbleed; guitar

tones are well-rounded with decent detailing. The YMP 35 scores halfway between the better YMP 30 and the inferior YMP 18. The two Zebronic's players—the Beta and the Gamma sound good—comfortably high volumes, good bass, and with a full mid-range.



SanDisk Sansa Express
A Li'l monsta in disguise

Conclusion

We were quite honestly, (and pleasantly), surprised to see the

performance that these minnows put forth. A good product with serious value for money is always a good thing, since one purchase will encourage several more from people who come in touch with the owner and his or her positive experience. The fact that we've seen a few of these players in the hands of various commuters aboard buses / trains simply means that market penetration is quite good.

If you look at our graphs, you'll see a strange phenomenon—the cheaper PMPs in this category offer superb performance for the money, while the costlier players don't offer a proportional bang for the buck. This clearly means that hikes in price in these sub-Rs 5,000 products come with a minimal hike in value—something we were alarmed to see.

Apple iPod Touch 8 GB: Thy Palm Over Flo-eth!

When Apple announced a PMP based on their iPhone concept, many of us were excited—for the first time we'd have freedom from menus, complicated sequences of button presses to achieve a simple task, and the ability to navigate a device at our leisure. After all, exploration is a leisurely activity, isn't it? Now that we've used the iPod Touch, we must say it's an experience that's been conceptualised exceptionally well and executed with the same panache and finesse that Apple has been known for. Once you play around with the Touch, feeling it and exploring its world, chances are you're already doomed to shell out the 17,000-odd Rupees that it takes to own one. And people will want to possess such a device with the same fervour that wannabe rich-boys chase Lamborghinis and Playboy Playmates with. And all this even before you listen to what it can do to your senses!

The Touch incorporates excellent sound, with the kind of tonal neutrality that most run-of-the-mill PMPs can only dream of. With a bass response approaching perfection, a deep hit-in-the-gut feeling that can only come with expensive speakers, the Touch sounds equally at ease with Heavy Metal as it does with Jazz or Blues, or even Rock

music where liquidity of response is the name of the game. With class-leading vocals and mids, the Touch has a revealing top end that's clear and precise without being overly bright.

It's a photo viewer well above par, and you'll love the way browsing through photos is as simple as flipping through an album. As if to prove its "touch" status, there's a single button on the facia whose sole aim is to return to the main menu, regardless of where you are. It's a very good video player too, and will satisfy even movie junkies with its large, crisp and clear screen.

The integrated WiFi ensures that you're connected even while...err...disconnected, even as the Safari Web browser makes a snap of surfing the Internet. Initial firmware issues had us bothered about the sluggishness of the browser, but that's history with the version 1.1 firmware. With the ability to flash your device online, and the use of the entire storage space as a Flash drive, the Touch also boldly goes where no previous iPod (save the very recent 3G Nano and 5.5G Classic) has gone before.

Its one of those rare *must have* lifestyle products, like a Nokia N95 8GB, or even a BMW M3—one of those flashy yet functional devices that doesn't really deserve your hard earned cash, but demands it...

How We Tested

We divided our PMPs into two categories:
1. Flash-based
2. Hard Drive-based

We further divided the flash category into price based segments:

- 1. Flash-based players up to Rs 5,000
- 2. Flash-based players from Rs 5,001 to Rs 10,000
- 3. Flash-based players above Rs 10,000

For a look at the features we graded, turn over to our tables. For performance, we tested the audio and video performance of each player. Audio performance has been given greater weightage, simply because this is more of a priority for most people.

On the video front, we judged each player's display quality in general for multimedia content.

Alongside is a list of the audio tracks used and what we looked at in each track.

Good music requires equally good gear, and the bundled earplugs aren't any good if one is to make a comparison. We used a pair of supra-aural Grado SR60s, a

Tracks	What We Looked At
Eagles— <i>Hotel California</i>	The lead guitar in the beginning, drum bass, male vocals. There are a couple of places where minor nuances like the the artists hand moving along the guitar body can be heard, something we looked out for
The Corrs— <i>Brid og ni Mhaille</i>	Very good track for female vocals. Voice timbre, accurate tonal balance and vocal texture is of utmost importance. Accompanying instruments are mostly higher frequencies, soundstaging is also important
Charlotte Church— <i>Bridge over Troubled Water</i>	Strong female vocals. Charlotte Church has a lot of depth to her voice, and can take low and high octaves equally well
Pink Floyd— <i>Speak to Me / Breathe</i>	Sensitivity to low volume sounds, soundstaging, and accurate reproduction of electronically produced sounds
Dire Straits— <i>Sultans of Swing</i>	Guitar work is exemplary here. We look for clarity, and detailing around the 500 Hz mark (guitar frequency)
Guns N' Roses— <i>November Rain (Live)</i>	Fast drum attack, good array of instruments, lots of guitar fill-in
Eric Clapton— <i>Layla</i>	Male Vocals, and a lot of intricate guitar work make this one of the best blues songs to check for music quality
Chand Sifarish (Fanaa)	Good vocals, and a super hit song, drum and tabla accompaniments make for a melodious number with a lot of nuances to pick up
Beedi (Omkaara)	Female vocals, and a fast number, gives us a good idea of how the player will perform on most indipop albums

circum-aural Audio Technica ATH A900, and Bose's Intra Ear earplugs for our testing purposes. These headphones allowed us to listen to the finer nuances of each track. Each song was rated on a

scale of 1 to 10, taking an average of its performance on each headphone. After that, we tested each PMP with their bundled earplugs and rated their earplugs against the trio of reference cans.